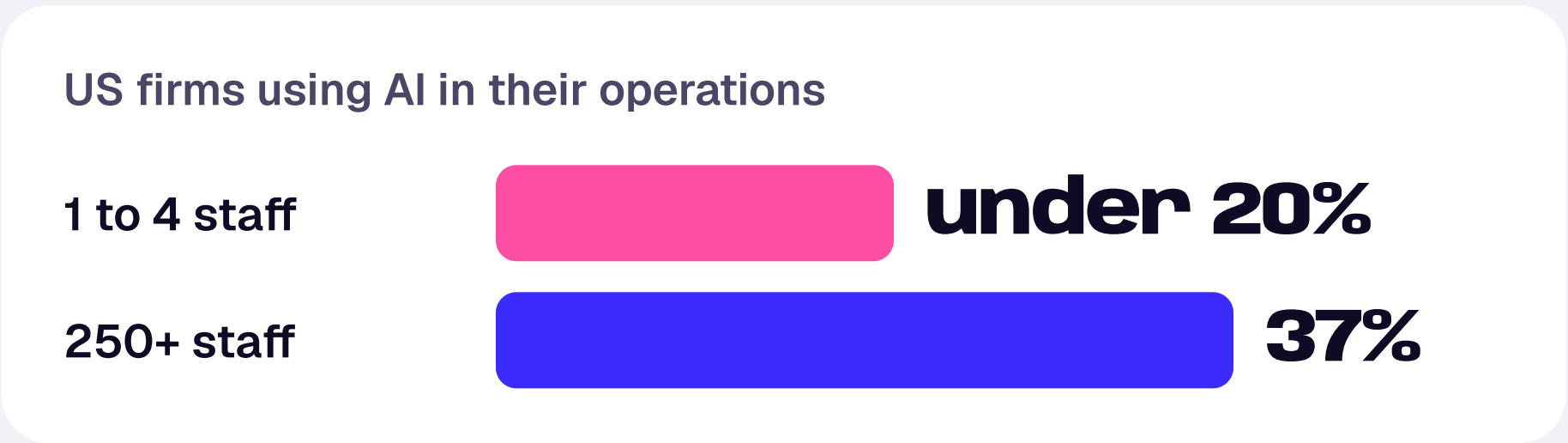
FOR SMALL BUSINESS OWNERS

THE MODEL IS THE CHEAPEST PART OF YOUR AI AGENT.

What an AI agent really costs a small business, with every sum shown.

FIRST, SOME CONTEXT

MOST SMALL FIRMS HAVEN'T STARTED YET.



A five-person business with no AI agent is in the majority. There's no rush to buy a platform, but there is a reason to get the budget right.

US Census Bureau, May 2026. All US firms: 17% to 20%, Dec 2025 to May 2026.

THE SUM

3,000 customer conversations a month costs

$5–$216

a month in AI model fees.

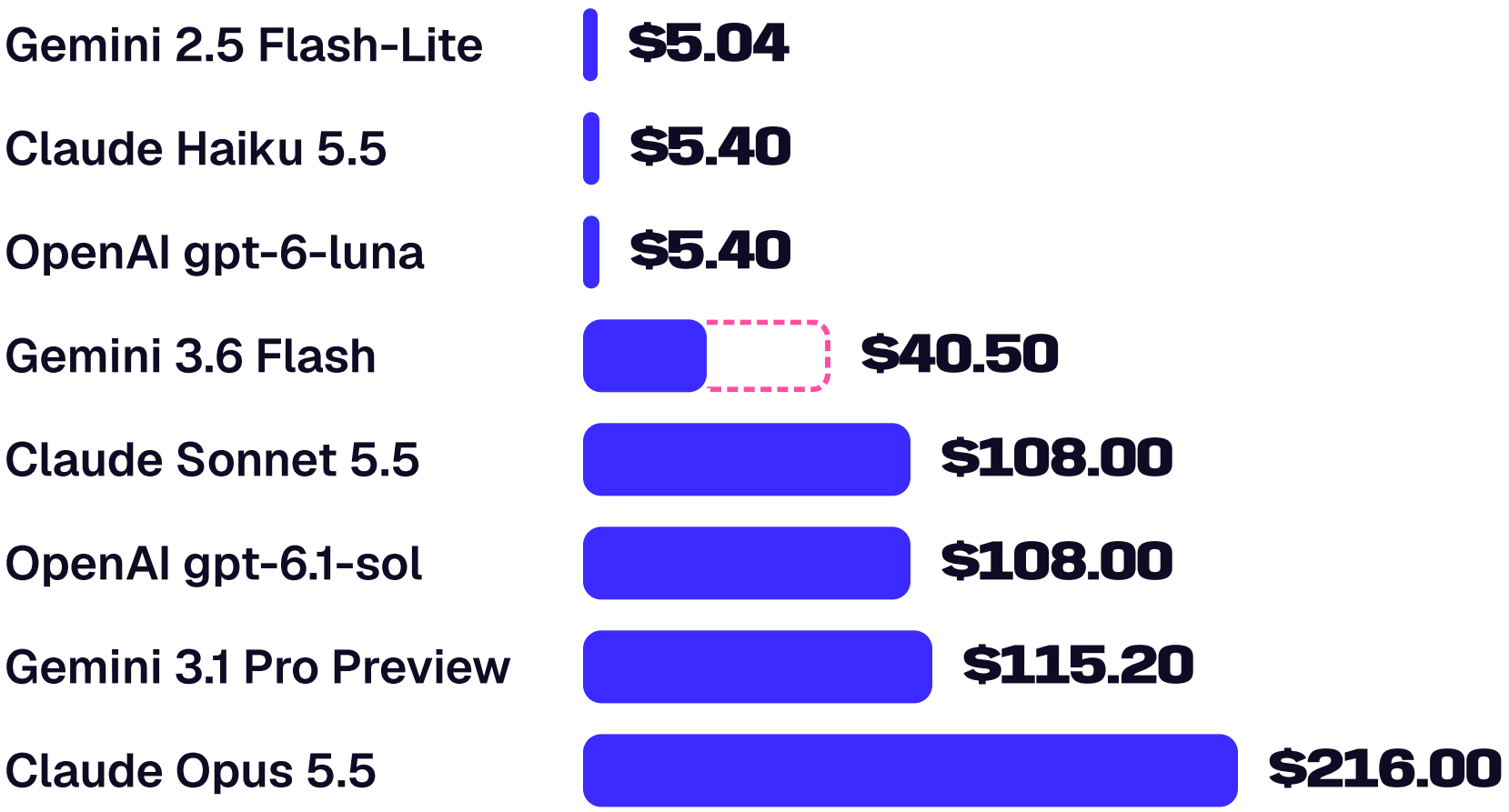
That's between 0.17 and 7.2 cents a conversation, depending on the model you pick.

Worked example: 4 model calls per conversation, about 3,000 input and 300 output tokens per call, no caching or batch discounts.

SAME WORKLOAD, 8 MODELS

START WITH THE SMALLEST MODEL THAT PASSES YOUR TESTS.

Monthly model fees, 3,000 conversations



Each provider's own pricing page, checked Oct 21, 2026. Step up a size only where the small model keeps failing.

SO WHERE DOES THE MONEY GO?

THREE BUCKETS, NOT ONE.

1 **BUILD** ONE-OFF

Integrations and testing. For a bought tool: setup and loading your help content.

2 **RUNNING** MONTHLY

Model fees, hosting, a vector database for document search, and monitoring.

3 **UPKEEP** PEOPLE TIME

Checking answers, fixing integrations when apps change, re-testing when models change.

Upkeep is the bucket most budgets forget.

WHAT SETS THE BUILD COST

TWO QUESTIONS MATTER MORE THAN THE MODEL.

QUESTION 1

How many of your systems does it connect to?

Each one needs authentication, error handling and tests. A documented API is a different job from a legacy tool with none.

QUESTION 2

What can it do without a person checking?

A read-only agent can be wrong without breaking anything. Once it changes records, you need permissions, confirmation steps, an audit log and a way to undo.

AFTER LAUNCH

MODEL PRICES MOVE ON PUBLISHED DATES.

Gemini 3.6 Flash, input, per million tokens

$0.75 → **$1.50**

TO DEC 31, 2026 FROM JAN 1, 2027

1 **Keep 50 to 100 real test questions**

Re-run them every time a model or prompt changes, or you're testing by feel.

2 **Budget people time**

Someone reads a sample of conversations each week. A few hours a week at first (our estimate).

3 **Set aside 15 to 20% of the build a year**

Our planning figure for owning any custom software. Agents sit at the top of it.

BUY OR BUILD?

OFF THE SHELF WINS MORE OFTEN THAN AGENCIES ADMIT.

$0.99 **per outcome** for Intercom's Fin agent. At 1,000 outcomes a month that's $11,880 a year, and the bill keeps coming.

A tool you already pay for covers the job	→ Switch on its built-in AI agent
A few steps between apps you already use	→ A workflow tool like n8n or Zapier
Your own systems or sensitive data	→ A custom agent, read-only first

Intercom pricing page, checked Oct 21, 2026.

WILL IT PAY FOR ITSELF?

A ONE-MINUTE BREAK-EVEN CHECK.

Full monthly cost

Running costs, upkeep hours, the build spread over 12 to 24 months

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Loaded hourly cost

Wages plus taxes and overheads

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Staff hours it must save every month just to break even

If that's more hours than the task takes today, stop there. Use the agent's real resolution rate from a pilot, not a vendor's headline.

HOW TO START WITHOUT WASTING MONEY

ONE JOB. READ-ONLY. ONE MONTH.

1 **Pick one job with volume and a clear right answer**

Order-status questions or invoice entry, not a do-everything chatbot.

2 **Write 50 to 100 real examples**

With the answer you'd want. It becomes your test set.

3 **Build it read-only**

The agent drafts, a person approves. A prototype on real data takes 2 to 3 weeks.

4 **Run it for a month on real traffic**

Track drafts approved, edited and rejected, every hand-off, and fees per conversation.

5 **Widen in steps**

Low-risk replies first, then actions, then a second job.

Durations: Arrowbin estimates, 2026.

YOUR TURN

HAVE ONE JOB YOU'D HAND TO AN AI AGENT?

Describe it in a sentence. We'll tell you whether a tool you already pay for can do it, and if not, what a read-only pilot would involve.

Full guide and every source in the comments

Save this for your next budget meeting